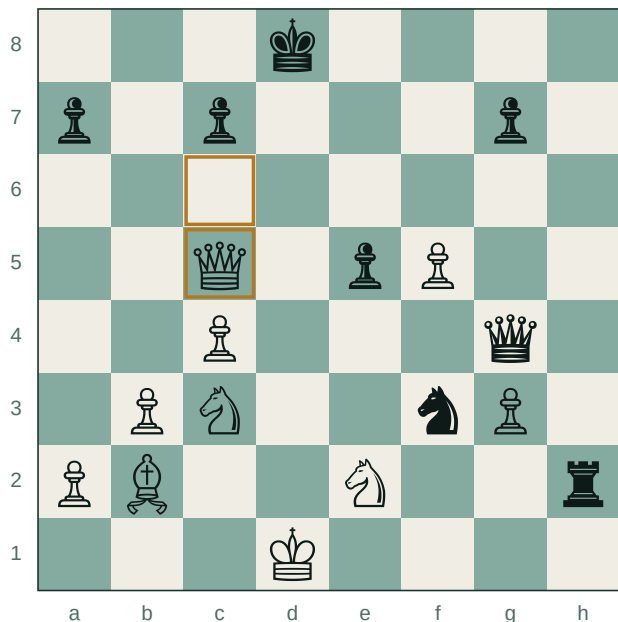


Exposed-king tactics: Black, move 24

Exposed-king tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 24.Qxc5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

24...Rh1+ 25. Kc2 Qxf5+ 26. Ne4 Qxe4+

24...Rh1+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **25.Kc2**.

25...Qxf5+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on f5. Recorded reply: **26.Ne4**.

26...Qxe4+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From e4 it attacks king on c2 and knight on e2.

At the end, nominal material is White 19 / Black 21 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4:** the balance goes from -2 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on d1. Geometrically undefended: queen on c5 and bishop on b2. Check for tactical protection.